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CALL FROM THE BASTION From left, BJP national general secretary Tarun Chugh, Union minister of state Jitendra Singh, Union home minister Amit Shah and other leaders at a campaign rally in Jammu

WHILE THE BJP SWEPT JAMMU, ITS STRATEGY OF USING ALLEGED PROXIES IN KASHMIR TO CUT INDIA BLOC'S VOTES FAILED

voted with responsibility. Now, it is the responsibility of our alliance to give a clean government which will deliver on the expectations of the people."

For Omar, the biggest challenge is dealing with the central government and getting it to move quickly on restoring statehood to Jammu & Kashmir, as promised by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. For only then will he have the powers to tackle the major problems that J&K faces. After the win, Omar chose his words carefully when he talked of dealing with the Centre, saying that he wanted a cordial rather than a hostile relationship with it. He added that "it would need two hands to clap"—meaning that he expected the Centre to be helpful and cooperative. As regards concerns that restoration of statehood may be delayed, Omar told India Today TV, "I would like to be believe the honourable PM who has committed to restoring statehood. I don't recall a speech where he said statehood would be restored only when the BJP is in power or that if the people of J&K do not vote for the BJP, they will be punished." Omar has said that the first resolution of the J&K Legislative Assembly will be on the restoration of statehood. "The central government is under obligation to restore statehood to Jammu and Kashmir, but there is no deadline," says a JKNC leader. "But we have options, like having the Supreme Court address the issue. Our presence in the government can build pressure on New Delhi and we will ensure people know what is happening. Until now, there has been no one to stop their *firmans* (orders)."

PROMISES TO KEEP

In its manifesto, the JKNC has pronounced 12 guarantees, including restoration of Article 370, pushing for an India-Pakistan dialogue on Kashmir ensuring the release of political prisoners and introduction of laws to reserve land and job rights for locals. Omar says that his top priority is to address people's everyday issues, such as jobs, inflation and provision of civic utilities. This will mean implementing his promise of freebies, like electricity, gas and food. However, with the Centre dispensing and controlling much of the finances in the state, Omar will have to maintain cordial relations to get even this job done. Many in Kashmir argue that this is an opportunity for the JKNC to be a pan Jammu and Kashmir party and re-